Love Over Time

A Soundtrack of Romantic Relationships Across the Life Course

Thesis

This soundtrack follows romantic relationships from adolescent attraction to later-life companionship. It presents love as a developmental process rather than a single emotion. Across the ten tracks, romantic relationships move from first attention and passion toward communication, conflict, loss, reflection, care, commitment, maintenance, and shared time. The sequence connects personal song choices to concepts from HDFS 225: Close Relationships, especially relationship development across the lifespan, attraction, social cognition, communication, love, commitment, maintenance, conflict, and dissolution.

Soundtrack Sequence

1. *Reality* — Richard Sanderson
2. *Golden Hour* — JVKE
3. *Always Online* — JJ Lin
4. *Heartbeat* — Leehom Wang
5. *Appearing and Leaving* — Liang Bo
6. *The Answer* — Yang Kun and Guo Caijie
7. *Make You Feel My Love* — Adele
8. *I Do* — Karen Mok
9. *Slowly Falling in Love with You* — Karen Mok
10. *Time in a Bottle* — Jim Croce

Reality — Richard Sanderson

I selected *Reality* to represent the first moment when romantic attention begins to feel different from ordinary friendship. The title suggests a movement from imagination into an emotionally meaningful experience: a crush becomes something that feels present and real. This placement connects to Lecture 14, "Relationship Across the Lifespan," which explains that adolescence is a period when attachment relationships begin to expand beyond the family. Adolescents typically move from same-sex friendships to mixed-gender friendships and then to romantic relationships, with crushes playing an important role in practicing new relational roles and social expectations. The lecture also explains that early romantic relationships can become a blueprint for later relationships. Therefore, this song begins the soundtrack at adolescence rather than at marriage or adult partnership. It captures attraction as an opening stage of development, before intimacy and commitment have fully formed.

Golden Hour — JVKE

I selected *Golden Hour* because its title transforms romantic love into a brief period of extraordinary light. The image reflects the idealizing quality of early passionate love, when a partner and the relationship can appear more perfect than they may be in everyday life. Lecture 11 introduces Sternberg's Triangular

Theory of Love and defines passion as physical arousal, excitement, and desire. Lecture 7 adds that positive illusions involve seeing a partner and the relationship in the best possible light; these illusions can be associated with greater satisfaction as long as they remain realistic. The same lecture distinguishes romanticized beliefs from realistic beliefs: romanticized beliefs may produce high initial satisfaction but can create problems when conflict appears. I chose this track to show the emotional intensity of falling in love while also suggesting that the "golden hour" is a particular stage, not the permanent condition of a relationship.

Always Online — JJ Lin

I selected *Always Online* to represent a relationship that must be maintained across distance through technology. The title turns digital availability into a symbol of emotional connection: being reachable becomes one way partners communicate presence when they cannot share the same physical space. Lecture 5 explains that long-distance relationships can succeed and that partners may have longer, more positive, and more intimate conversations, even though reunions can create uncertainty. Lecture 9 describes technology as a mixed blessing. Digital communication can connect people across long distances and help maintain relationships, but it can also produce misunderstandings, jealousy, and ambiguous information. Lecture 13 makes the connection even more specific by identifying technology-mediated communication and future thinking as important maintenance processes for long-distance couples. This song belongs early in emerging adulthood because modern relationship development includes online dating, long-distance relationships, and living apart together rather than following one fixed path.

Heartbeat — Leehom Wang

I selected *Heartbeat* for the point when a relationship becomes emotionally difficult and communication is no longer effortless. The title uses a bodily signal to suggest anxiety, uncertainty, and the intensity that remains when partners do not know how to move forward. Lecture 8 defines an interpersonal gap as a situation in which one person's intention does not match the impact on the other person. It recommends active listening, perception checking, mutual inquiry, and explaining intentions as ways to reduce miscommunication. Lecture 17 presents conflict as an incompatibility in partners' desires, opinions, or actions. Conflict can escalate through negative affect reciprocity or a demand-withdraw pattern, while repair attempts and collaborative conflict styles offer more constructive alternatives. I chose this song to show that love does not prevent conflict. Instead, conflict reveals whether partners can communicate, regulate negative emotion, and respond to each other's concerns before dissatisfaction becomes a larger relationship problem.

Appearing and Leaving — Liang Bo

I selected *Appearing and Leaving* to represent relationship dissolution and the emotional disruption that follows separation. The title emphasizes movement between presence and absence, which makes the song useful for showing that a breakup is not only one final moment. Lecture 19 describes several ways relationships end, including withdrawal, open confrontation, mediated communication, manipulation, and gradual de-escalation. It also explains that the experience of breaking up is shaped by whether a person initiated the ending, was rejected, or reached a mutual decision. After dissolution, people often

need social support, revise their memories, and reconstruct a sense of self outside the relationship. The lecture's final point is especially important: relationship endings may result less from one accumulation of negative events than from the deterioration of positive experiences. I chose this track because it places loss inside the life course. A relationship can end, but the attachment, routines, memories, and lessons created by that relationship do not disappear immediately.

The Answer — Yang Kun and Guo Caijie

I selected *The Answer* as the conceptual turning point of the soundtrack. After attraction, passion, conflict, and loss, the speaker is no longer simply asking whether love feels intense; the title asks what love should mean. Lecture 7 distinguishes romanticized relationship beliefs from realistic beliefs. Romanticized beliefs treat love as the most important basis for choosing a partner and may assume that truly loving couples should not experience conflict. Realistic beliefs instead emphasize growth through obstacles. Lecture 11 also presents several forms of love, including storge, or companionate love based on trust and respect; agape, or patient and self-sacrificing love; and pragma, or practical and realistic love. The lecture's comparison of cultural expectations about love further shows that romantic meaning is shaped by social context. I chose this song to mark a shift from asking how love feels to asking what love requires. It prepares the second half of the soundtrack, where love becomes care, choice, and sustained practice.

Make You Feel My Love — Adele

I selected *Make You Feel My Love* because its title is organized around an action directed toward another person. Instead of focusing only on the speaker's excitement, it asks how love can be communicated and experienced by a partner. Lecture 11 defines agape as self-sacrificing, kind, and patient love, while storge is peaceful and affectionate love based on mutual trust and respect. Lecture 13 explains that relationship enhancement includes generosity, gratitude, openness, assurances, and other behaviors that communicate care. These behaviors work best when the partner actually perceives them. This song therefore represents a more mature stage of romantic love in which emotional support and responsiveness become central. I chose it to show the movement from passion toward dependable care. The song's title functions as the key evidence: love is not only an internal feeling but also something a partner can make visible through support, reassurance, and willingness to remain present during difficulty.

I Do — Karen Mok

I selected *I Do* to represent the transition into long-term partnership and marriage. The title is a short statement, but it also functions as a decision and a promise. Lecture 12 defines commitment as a long-term orientation toward a relationship and explains that commitment is influenced by satisfaction, alternatives, and investments. Once established, commitment makes partners more likely to maintain the relationship, accommodate each other constructively, and minimize alternatives. The lecture also distinguishes personal commitment, structural commitment, and moral commitment, showing that staying in a relationship can involve desire, practical constraints, or values. This distinction prevents the song from treating marriage as proof that a relationship is automatically healthy. I chose *I Do* because it represents a deliberate choice to build a shared future after the uncertainty of earlier stages. In the life

course, it belongs in the transition into adulthood, when partners may decide whether to move from dating toward a more permanent relationship structure.

Slowly Falling in Love with You — Karen Mok

I selected *Slowly Falling in Love with You* because the word "slowly" emphasizes accumulation through ordinary time rather than one dramatic moment. The song represents the everyday work that allows long-term love to continue after the initial intensity of passion changes. Lecture 13 defines relationship maintenance as the strategic actions people take to sustain a partnership, keep it satisfying, repair it, or preserve a particular relationship state. The lecture identifies positivity, openness, assurances, shared social networks, shared tasks, and joint leisure as communicative maintenance strategies. Lecture 11 similarly explains that passionate love often decreases over time while partners may continue to feel love, and that commitment and intimacy can increase with age. I chose this track to make maintenance visible. Long-term love is not maintained only through anniversaries or major promises; it is also built through repeated conversations, shared routines, small acts of care, and the decision to keep participating in one another's daily lives.

Time in a Bottle — Jim Croce

I selected *Time in a Bottle* as the final track because its title makes shared time feel finite and therefore emotionally valuable. The song represents later-life reflection, when the meaning of a relationship is connected to memories, mortality, and the years partners have experienced together. Lecture 14 explains that late adulthood can involve greater awareness of mortality, changing health, retirement, caregiving, and the possibility of widowhood. It also introduces socioemotional selectivity theory, which suggests that people increasingly prioritize emotionally meaningful relationships as they become more aware of limited time. Lecture 11 adds that older couples often experience less intense emotion and greater emotional stability, while commitment and intimacy may increase with age. I chose this song to complete the movement from falling in love to living with love over time. At the end of the soundtrack, love is no longer measured only by passion. It is measured by shared history, emotional meaning, and the limited time two people are able to have together.

Course Materials Referenced

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 5, "Attraction and Mate Selection." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 7, "Social Cognition Bias." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 8, "Communication." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 9, "Relationships in the Modern World Technology." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 11, "Love and Satisfaction." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 12, "Theories of Commitment." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 13, "Relationship Maintenance." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 14, "Social Context: Understanding Relationship Diversity." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 17, "Conflict." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.

HDFS 225: Close Relationships. Lecture 19, "Relationship Dissolution." University of Illinois, Fall 2026.